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A bill to protect lawmakers + Taxing guns and ammo? + Republicans want a gas tax holiday

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Good morning and welcome to the A.M. Alert!

BILL WOULD ALLOW LAWMAKERS TO USE CAMPAIGN FUNDS FOR SECURITY

Citing harassment, stalking, threats and actual violence against state lawmakers, Assemblywoman Mia Bonta, D-Alameda, on Tuesday unveiled AB 37, a bill that would allow political candidates and elected officials to use campaign funds to hire security for themselves, their families and their staff.

Current law allows candidates and elected officials to pay for in-home or office security systems with campaign funds, but only when a threat has been verified by law enforcement and only for the candidate or elected official

“As public servants, there is a lot we sacrifice to serve, this includes spending time with family and our privacy. However, the one thing we should never be willing or expected to give up is our sense of safety. Unfortunately, we have seen an increase in threats against public officials, especially women, and harassment against legislative staff who are serving the constituents who elected us to office,” Bonta said in a statement.

Bonta’s office cited threats to Democratic lawmakers, including Sens. Richard Pan and Scott Wiener, as rationale for the bill.

The bill’s introduction was timely.

On Tuesday, Wiener received both a bomb threat at his home address and a threat to shoot up his Sacramento office.

“Since I was first elected to public office in 2010, we’ve seen a terrifying spike in threats and violence against elected officials — myself included. It’s been harrowing to deal with endless threats on social media; I’ve gotten thousands over the past few years,” Wiener said in a statement provided by Bonta’s office.

ANOTHER FIREARM TAX ATTEMPT?

California lawmakers are trying again to pass an excise tax for guns and ammunition, with proceeds going toward a variety of gun violence prevention measures.

Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, has introduced AB 28 as part of a trio of bills aimed at reducing gun violence. The others are AB 29, which would allow Californians to voluntarily add their name to a “Do Not Sell” list for firearms, and AB 36, which prohibits people subject to domestic violence restraining orders from purchasing or possessing a firearm for three years after the expiration of the order.

“Californians are counting on us to do everything possible to keep them safe from mass shootings and gun violence,” Gabriel said in a statement. “Taxing guns and ammunition sales will enable us to fund more school safety measures and expand proven violence prevention programs. We can and must do more to protect our kids and our communities.”

AB 28, as it appears online, does not currently specify how much the excise tax on firearms and ammunition would be.

A 2019 bill from Assemblyman Marc Levine would have implemented a $25 excise tax on the sale of all handguns and semiautomatic rifles. That bill died in committee.

REPUBLICANS TO PURSUE GAS TAX HOLIDAY AGAIN

Last session, legislative Republicans tried, and failed, to pass a suspension of California's gas tax. With lawmakers poised to address rising gas prices in the special session, Republicans are once again introducing that proposal.

Assemblyman Vince Fong, R-Bakersfield, on Tuesday announced a pair of bills, AB 53 and ABX1 2 (one for the regular session and one for the special session), that would suspend the gas tax for one year.

Fong's office noted that Californians pay more than $1.20 per gallon more than other state residents because of taxes, fees and mandates.

"Persistent inflation continues to cause painful financial burdens on California families," Fong said in a statement. "We must do what we can to help ease these difficulties immediately."

Given that the Democrats control a supermajority in the Senate and Assembly, the bill is unlikely to get very far. A previous attempt was gutted and amended into a bill to tax oil company windfall profits — exactly what Gov. Gavin Newsom has proposed that the Legislature do during this special session.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

California State Library spokesman Alex Vassar has been hard at work tabulating the closest legislative races in California history. In terms of margin percentages, the Central Valley race between Democratic Sen. Melissa Hurtado and Republican David Shepard is the closest. Via Twitter.

Best of The Bee:

Police are investigating multiple death threats against State Sen. Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco, including a bomb threat that listed his home address, via Andrew Sheeler.State officials on Tuesday announced they will begin the process of closing Chuckwalla Valley State Prison in Riverside County and are planning cutbacks at six more prisons, including a women's facility in Sacramento County, via Rosalio Ahumada.A California lawmaker is reviving legislation that would clear zoning hurdles for houses of worship and nonprofit colleges seeking to build affordable housing on vacant land, via Lindsey Holden.

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